

What is space?

Our place in space

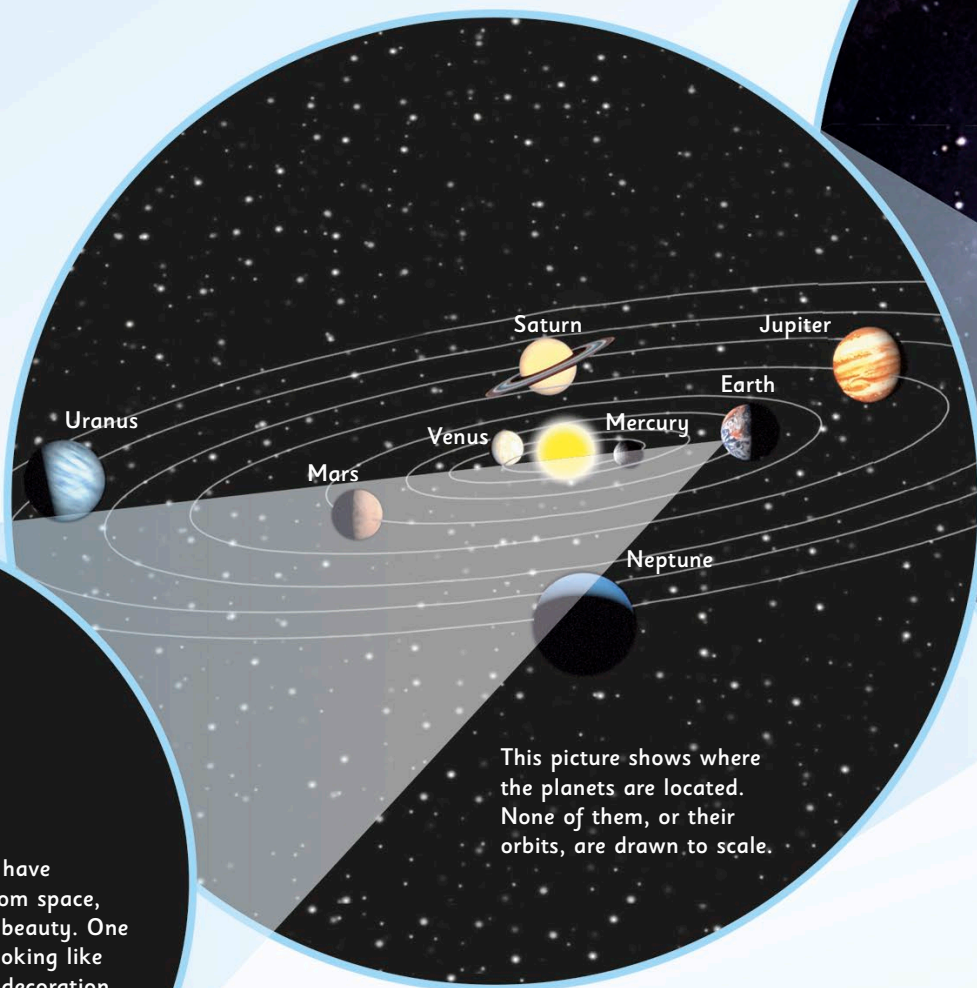
The Earth seems huge to us – after all, it can take you a long time just to travel to school! But the Earth is only a very tiny part of space. So where exactly does it belong in the Universe?



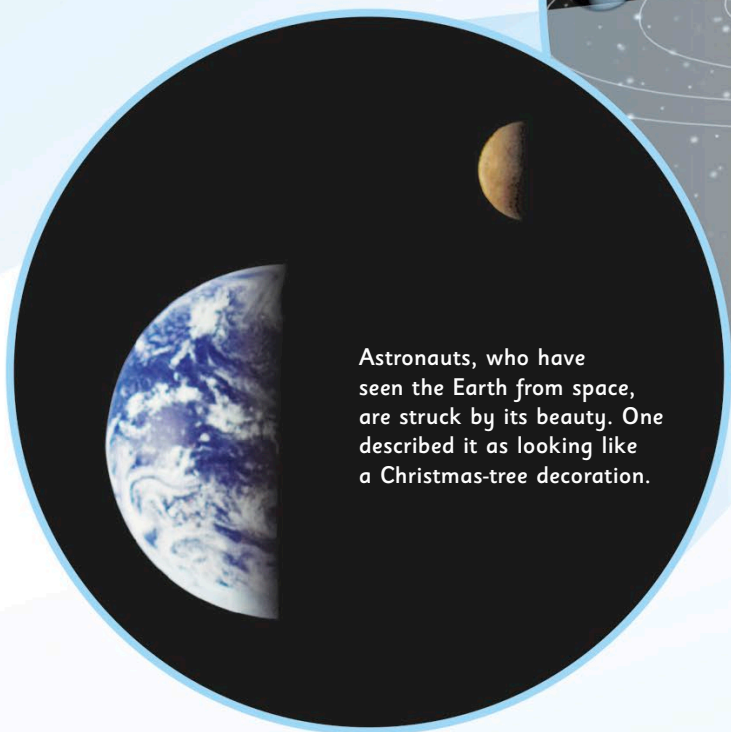
The Earth looks like a swirly blue marble suspended in space.

The Earth and its moon

The Earth, our home in space, has one natural satellite – the Moon. It is about one quarter of the size of the Earth and, on average, orbits about 384,000 km (240,000 miles) away from us.



This picture shows where the planets are located. None of them, or their orbits, are drawn to scale.



Astronauts, who have seen the Earth from space, are struck by its beauty. One described it as looking like a Christmas-tree decoration.

The solar system

The Earth is the third planet from the Sun, at just the right distance from it to support life. The eight planets that orbit the Sun (plus moons, comets, asteroids, meteoroids, dwarf planets, dust, and gas) make up our solar system.